

I often hear sweeping pronouncements made about the stock market and where it's going from pundits and investors everywhere, as I'm sure you do too. I also notice how so many people take such guesses seriously.

However, I'm not going to suggest we should all stop guessing. That's asking too much.

But I'd advise holding all such opinions loosely and with a great deal of humility. After all, how many people in March 2009 thought the market would rally 80 percent in less than two years? Not many, that's for sure.

Yet, it happened. No one could have forecast the Gulf oil spill happening when it did, either.

Over the course of an investing life, stuff is going to happen — both good and bad — that no one saw coming. Instead of playing the guessing game, focus on the opportunities in front of you.

And there are always, in all markets, many opportunities. Yes, always!

Graham pointed out — in 1976 — there were over 5,000 publicly traded securities. (Today there are over three times that number, especially if you consider the international markets.) Then he said, "Following a wide variety of approaches and preferences, the individual investor should at all times be able to locate at least 1% of the total list — say, thirty issues or more — that offer attractive buying opportunities."

That's true. When someone tells me they can't find anything worth buying in this market, they are just not looking hard enough. With 10,000 securities today, even one-half of 1 percent is 50 names. Kind of makes you think, doesn't it?

What I've Learned from Over a Decade of Writing Newsletters

I started writing newsletters professionally in February 2004. Before that, I was a freelance writer, investment hobbyist and professional banker (corporate lender, to be exact). After I hit the 10-year mark, in 2015, I thought it was a good time to look back over the results. So, I finally got my letter's track record independently verified.